



AI workspace for immigration operations



The AI agent that automates the *entirety* of
immigration.

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Built by someone the system was built to keep out.

Sammy Abdella

Founder & CEO — Columbia University, B.S. Computer Science

At 18, Sammy fled Tunisia — where being gay is criminalized — escaping a pending death penalty. He taught himself English on public-library computers, earned admission to Columbia, and lived the immigration system as a lifeline. He is building Ellis on his own O-1 petition today.

An AI researcher and engineer, he turned down an offer at Google to build Ellis — named after the island that once welcomed America's immigrants.



Immigration is expensive because the work is manual and scattered.

PDFs / email / Slack / spreadsheets / portals / notices

Employers pay too much to sponsor immigrants because the process is lengthy and full of tasks AI can automate faster and cheaper.

Immigrants waste time on filings that can be automated and money on routine questions AI can answer instantly.

Lawyers lose too many hours to automatable tasks and scattered inbox workflows.

Immigration is not one filing. It is a *recurring operating system*.

Every case runs for years, across the same lifecycle — and today it lives in inboxes, spread across three parties who never share a source of truth.



What it costs today

- Routine operational work is billed at attorney rates.
- Documents scatter across email, Slack, HRIS, and government portals.
- Missed deadlines, expirations, and RFEs quietly become denials.

Why it persists

- Employer, employee, and counsel never see the same status.
- Legacy tools digitize forms — they don't do the work.
- Lawyers are trapped chasing documents instead of practicing law.

Ellis turns scattered inputs into a managed immigration case.

Employees, employers, and counsel share one AI-assisted workspace for a faster, cheaper process.

01
Connect the case

Employee and employer documents, plus context from Slack, email, HRIS, portals, and notices.

02
Build the case

AI extracts facts, checks evidence, finds gaps, and tracks deadlines.

03
Coordinate everyone

Shared tasks, status, approvals, reminders, and AI question assistance.

04
Run the lifecycle

AI builds cases, manages filings, runs daily compliance audits, and automates renewals, travel, and ongoing operations.

Ellis does the work around the legal decision.

Lawyers still approve filings. Ellis automates the operational layer around them.

Document review

Extract every field; flag what's missing or expiring.

AI question help

Case-grounded answers for every stakeholder.

Risk flags

Surface compliance and filing risk before it bites.

Notice summaries

Turn an RFE or notice into clear, owned actions.

Form preparation

Pre-fill immigration forms from the case file.

Evidence packets

Assemble counsel-ready bundles in one click.

Before Ellis, the work is operational. With Ellis, it shifts to legal judgment — less inbox work, more legal leverage.

One workflow. Three economic winners.

Ellis removes the operational work that makes immigration slow, expensive, and confusing.

Employees

Use AI question assistance, know exactly what to upload, and avoid lawyer fees for routine help.

Employers

Automate onboarding, hiring, compliance, renewals, and immigration tasks across the workforce.

Lawyers

Receive complete, structured case files; spend less time on document review, evidence chasing, and prep.

Lower counsel fees, faster cycles, and fewer missed obligations.

Three weeks old — already in revenue and enterprise demand.

Ellis started just three weeks ago. The product is already built, sold, and in conversations with enterprises.

\$1K

MRR — first paying customer, live today

2 LOIs

Signed intent: VPEA and qq.com (Tencent)

3 weeks

From zero to product, revenue, and demos

US + CA

Work, study & travel — any country of origin

A full product — three role-based workspaces and 12 live AI capabilities — built end-to-end by a solo founder, already in market.



MARKET

\$4T+ global TAM

Bottoms-up global TAM across the workflow layers Ellis can ultimately power.



Start with the core wedge.



Immigration workflows



Document authenticity
+ translation



Mobility, compliance,
and employer ops

Ellis expands from immigration operations into the broader global mobility workflow stack.

\$300B+
core wedge

Immigration + visa services +
document authenticity + translation +
workflow + compliance.

Large, recurring, and underserved.

Recurring by nature — every visa renews, every employee re-files, every year.

LAYER	DEFINITION	SIZE
TAM	Global immigration legal & services spend	\$30B+
SAM	US + Canada employment, study & travel operations	\$9B
SOM	Tech-forward employers + immigration boutiques (3-yr)	\$500M

Market sizing reflects internal estimates from public immigration-services and legal-spend data.

Who Ellis is for — and why it wins.

US employers are legally on the hook for counsel fees of **\$10K+ per sponsored employee**. Ellis delivers the same outcome for a fraction — and does what no chatbot can.

Ideal customer profile

- Tech-forward employers sponsoring foreign talent — startups to mid-market (H-1B, O-1, L-1, PERM, Canadian work permits).
- Immigration boutiques and solo attorneys automating operational work.
- High-volume sponsors — universities, education & migration agencies (e.g., VPEA), and staffing firms.

Why not a lawyer, Claude, or ChatGPT?

- **Cheaper than counsel:** employers must pay ~\$10K+ per employee; Ellis costs a fraction.
- **Private by design:** general AI may store and train on uploaded data — unsafe for immigration files. Ellis keeps everything local.
- **Fewer tokens, right answer:** Ellis is tuned to each case, so it's far cheaper to run than raw Claude or ChatGPT.
- **It actually does the work:** a chat subscription can't file forms or work USCIS/IRCC portals. Ellis can.

Zeren, your path *is* this company's path.

You went **Tongji → Columbia → Tencent AI → backing technical founders**. Sammy went **Columbia CS → turned down Google → built Ellis solo**. Linear backs engineers who apply AI to real industry problems — and Ellis is exactly that.

Engineers backing engineers

Linear's core ethos. Ellis was architected and shipped end-to-end by one technical founder in three weeks — 3 products, 12 AI capabilities, on-device inference.

Vertical AI, not another base model

Linear backs AI applications that lift industry efficiency, not foundation models. Ellis collapses immigration's operational cost — your exact thesis.

The US–China door

Linear's worldview is the two AI superpowers. Ellis is the bridge that moves Chinese talent, students, and companies into the US and Canada.

A Tencent-rooted wedge

Your years in Tencent's Cloud & Smart Industry group map directly to our qq.com (Tencent) LOI and VPEA's China–Canada education pipeline.

Columbia to Columbia

You hold a Columbia M.S.; Sammy just earned his Columbia CS degree. Shared rigor, shared network, shared standard.

Data intelligence, applied

Ellis turns scattered, unstructured immigration documents into structured, governed case data — Linear's data-intelligence thesis in a \$30B vertical.

Raising *\$260K* to turn lived hardship into lasting infrastructure.

Funding the founder's O-1 petition, a 12-month runway, and the push from revenue today to scaled paid pilots.

\$260K

Funds product, go-to-market, and founder runway

12 mo

Runway to convert LOIs into recurring revenue

O-1

Founder immigration status secured in parallel